

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into the room. The quiet of something that has been going on for hours.

Two mugs on the side table. One steams. The other, further off, is stone cold with a skin on it.

MAYA, 30s, on the sofa, feet tucked under her, wearing his coat. It is too big in the sleeves. Her face is lit blue by her phone. Thumb moving. Scrolling. She has been scrolling for a long time.

JAMES, 30s, in the little kitchen, drying a mug. At home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases. A body that has decided it isn't alone.

Maya scrolls. Looks up at him. Scrolls.

MAYA
(not looking up)
That's the same mug.

JAMES
What?

MAYA
You've dried that one about six times.

JAMES
It's still wet.

MAYA
It's really not.

He keeps drying it. She keeps scrolling. Looks up. Down again.

JAMES
There was a heron on the tarn this morning.

MAYA
Yeah, you said.

JAMES
Same spot as yesterday.

MAYA
You said that as well. In the car.
And at lunch. And in the shop.

JAMES
It's a good heron.

MAYA
It's an incredible heron. I'm
thrilled for it.

Scroll. Look up. He has moved on to wiping a counter that is already clean.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You going to keep doing that?

JAMES
Doing what?

MAYA
Whatever this is.

JAMES
I'm tidying.

MAYA
It's a holiday let. Someone comes
and cleans it on Thursday. That's
what we paid for.

JAMES
I paid for.

It lands. Small. Petty. He didn't mean it to come out and it came out anyway. She stops scrolling for a second.

MAYA
Wow. Okay.

JAMES
I didn't mean--

MAYA
No, you did, and it's fine, I'll
transfer you.

She holds the phone up, taps something with her thumb, too
hard.

JAMES
Maya.

MAYA
Done. Sorted. We're square.

He puts the cloth down. Comes through. Sits. The armchair,
not the sofa. She clocks the distance. Goes back to her
phone.

He settles. And then, quiet, barely there, to the empty end
of the sofa nearest him, almost a smile:

JAMES
(barely)
Shove up.

Her thumb stops.

She looks at the empty cushion. Then at him.

MAYA
What did you say.

JAMES
Nothing.

MAYA
You said shove up.

JAMES
It's just a thing, it's a--

MAYA
Don't. I know what it is. I know
exactly what it is.

He rubs his face. Half a second where even he isn't sure.
Gone again.

She puts the phone face down on her knee. First time tonight.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES

Oh, here we go.

MAYA

Two. And the second one sweet. Two sugars. You don't take sugar. You have never once taken sugar since I've known you, and you stood there and stirred two sugars into a cup for--

JAMES

It's a cup of coffee.

MAYA

IT IS NOT A CUP OF COFFEE.

It rings off the stone walls. And she hears herself. On the surface it is, exactly, a cup of coffee. That is the thing she can never hold.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You asked me to come. You did. I didn't invite myself. You said come up for a few days, it'll be good, it'll be quiet.

JAMES

It is quiet.

MAYA

It's so quiet, James. It's the quietest place I've ever been.

She stands. Walks, because she can't sit. Picks up one of his jumpers from the back of a chair and folds it without thinking, the way you fold something you've folded a hundred times. Puts it down.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Do you know what it's like. Trying to compete with someone who isn't even here. I can't win. There's no way to win it. She doesn't get to annoy you. She doesn't get old. She doesn't fold your stuff wrong. She just gets to be gone. And perfect. And I'm the one who's still here.

JAMES

Don't.

MAYA

At least if she were alive I could
hate her properly.

It is out before she can stop it. It is too far. She knows
the second it lands.

JAMES

(quiet, and cold)

Say that again.

MAYA

I didn't--

JAMES

Go on. Say it again.

MAYA

I didn't mean it. James. I didn't
mean that.

JAMES

Yes you did. You keep a little
list, don't you. The sugars. The
coffees. Who I look at. Like you've
got a right to it.

That one finds the exact spot. She goes very still.

MAYA

Haven't I?

He doesn't answer.

He doesn't answer, and the not answering is the loudest
thing in the room.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Right.

JAMES

That's not what I--

MAYA

No, I heard you. I heard you fine.

She crosses to him. Takes his face in both hands. Hard.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Look at me. Am I here. Am I
actually in this room with you or
am I just, what, sat on the end of
it.

He looks. And for one second he is completely there, and she
hates how much she needs that second.

Then his eyes slide. Past her. To nothing. She feels his
face turn under her hands toward the empty air.

She lets go like it burned her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. There it is. I've got my
hands on your face and you still
went.

JAMES
(worn through)
I know. You've told me. You tell me
every time.

MAYA
Then stop doing it.

JAMES
You think I'm doing it on purpose?
You think I want--

MAYA
Put it down. Put it down for one
night. One. And just be here. With
me. Like you said you would.

JAMES
It isn't--

MAYA
Don't. Don't say it isn't that
simple. You could. You choose it.
Every single time you choose it
over me and then you call it
something happening to you.

JAMES
(up, loud)
It IS happening to me.

MAYA
Then let me in! Once. Let me into
the room, just--

JAMES
There's no room--

MAYA
There is always a room. There is
always a room in you and I have
never once been let in.

Silence. She is breathing hard. She looks down at the phone
still in her hand. Turns it round so he can see the screen.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There's a train from Oxenholme at
twenty to eight. I've been looking
at it for an hour.

He looks at the screen. Then at her.

JAMES
Then get it.

It is the cruellest thing he has said, and it is said
flatly, like he knows she won't. Like she always stays.

MAYA
(barely)
You think I won't.

He doesn't answer that either.

And then, because he said it, because he can't take it back
and can't stand it, he crosses to her. Not to comfort her.
To stop the moment existing. He takes her, and it isn't
tender, it's a collision. She shoves him in the chest, hard,
then grabs a fistful of his shirt and hauls him back in.
Teeth. Two people who know each other's bodies better than
they know what they are to each other.

For a second it might be enough.

Then she feels it. His breath at her ear, his face turned
away. She opens her eyes.

He is looking past her. Over her shoulder. At the room.
Holding her, and gone.

She shoves him off.

MAYA
You're... even now. Even now,
James. I have got my hands on you
and you are still--

She can't finish it. She's shaking.

He is already half-turned back toward the space.

JAMES
(to it, lost)
I don't even know if you're--

He can't finish either. He doesn't know who he's asking. He doesn't know if anyone's there.

He drifts to the window and opens it again, without knowing he's done it. The cold comes back in.

MAYA
You've opened it again. James. Look
at what you're doing.

He doesn't hear her. His hand comes up. Reaching toward the empty air beside him. Palm open. At a height. For a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. His own hand. The two mugs. The cold sweet coffee. The open window. Maya, in his coat. Himself. The empty end of the sofa. The whole shape of it, all at once.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and breaks.

MAYA
(small now, frightened)
James.

He isn't looking at her. He's looking at the air. He backs away from it, and it comes after him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(pleading, to no one she
can see)
Not now. Not tonight. Go on.
Please. Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

And there it is. The full size of it, finally, in her face.

JAMES
(a roar, torn out of him,
at nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. Back, hard, away from him, across the room,
over the broken mug, out through the open window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing. The gold window
shrinking below.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high over the roof. Looks down.

At the small lit cottage. At the one warm window. At the man
inside it, tiny now, both hands over his face.

And Maya behind him, still in his coat, her phone lit in her
hand. Not going to him. Not leaving either. Watching the man
she loves shake at an empty room, a broken cup at his feet,
and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look
at a place you have just been put out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.